The nature of the professional cricketer is changing. The T20 generation are global players, who are not necessary identified with one team. Jonny Bairstow is as Yorkshire as they come but reached a new constituency in his debut season in the IPL, where he averaged 55.62 at a strike rate of 157.24 for Sunrisers Hyderabad. He had barely got off the plane from India before he was into a World Cup training camp and scoring 126 in a one-day international against Pakistan.

The modern hybrid player has so more many opportunities to play; Buttler, for instance, represents Sydney Thunder in the Big Bash, while remaining grounded in county cricket for Lancashire. He played for Comilla Victorians in the Bangladesh Premier League. Dawid Malan took a pay cut, from playing T20 cricket in Bangladesh, to represent England in the Ashes in 2017, where he scored his maiden Test hundred at the WACA. Players shouldn't really have to make such a choice, but the economics of the game have changed as radically as their professional lifestyle.

Franchise cricket operates as a satellite system and answers a constant need for TV content. Malan, for instance, captains Middlesex but spent last winter playing for Cape Town Blitz in South Africa's Mzansi Super League, for Peshawar Zalmi in the Pakistan Super League, and for Khulna Titans in the Bangladesh Premier League.

Every sport wants to maximize its income and enhance its exposure, but sometimes you can have too much of a good thing. Crowds were down in the last edition of the Big Bash in Australia; they have been uniformly poor in the Caribbean Super League. It is easy to say the calendar should be rationalized, but professional principles apply.

Like other athletes in other sports facing identical issues, we play too much. That might not be as physically destructive in cricket as in, say, rugby, but there is a logical erosion of impact. Everyone needs a rest, but what happens when you are two weeks into a month off, and your agent calls with news that a franchise is offering £50,000 for three matches? The temptation to accept is enormous.

I've never been on that circuit. I missed the boat in one sense. I played a solitary season of T20 for Essex, and even scored an unbeaten 100 against Surrey in front of 17,000 at the Oval, but didn't have the desire to devise an effective method. I was set on becoming the best Test player I could be for England.